

decisive victory that had seemed so close the last two days. Longstreet again urged Lee to disengage and go around the Federal flank. Lee refused.

Meanwhile, General Meade held a council of war around midnight on July 2. He listened to his generals' opinions, and resolved to stay and fight it out. Both armies had suffered badly in the previous two days, but the Union army still held the high ground. Meade was determined to keep it.

At 1 p.m. on July 3, 150 Confederate cannons opened fire from Seminary Ridge in the greatest Southern artillery barrage of the war. Federal guns answered, and for two hours the ground shook with the impact of exploding shells. The noise could be heard as far away as Pittsburgh. Meant to smash Union positions on Cemetery Ridge, the bulk of the Confederate shells fell on the rearward slope, disrupting only hospitals and reserve artillery. Then suddenly the Federal counter-battery fire fell silent as Union artillerists cooled their overheated guns. Thinking he had suppressed them, Longstreet's artillery chief recommended that the infantry attack should begin, following Lee's plan of battle.